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**Roblox introduces new
safeguards for teens,
including age estimation
tech**



Roblox announced Thursday that it's launching new safeguards for people who are between the ages of 13 and 18. The company is introducing "Trusted Connections" to allow these users to connect more freely with people they know, alongside age estimation technology, more privacy tools, and insights for parents of teens.

Roblox has come under fire in recent years for how it handles child safety. In April, Florida Attorney General James I. O'Neil issued a subpoena to Roblox in response to reports that children were exposed to harmful material on the platform and that predatory adults were able to message minors on the app.

IMAGE CREDITS:

GARY JONES/BLOOMBERG / GETTY IMAGES

The changes announced Thursday are likely part of Roblox's efforts to appease both lawmakers and parents. The teen-focused update comes eight months after Roblox [launched protections](#) for users under the age of 13.

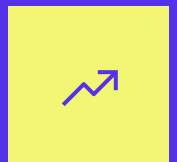
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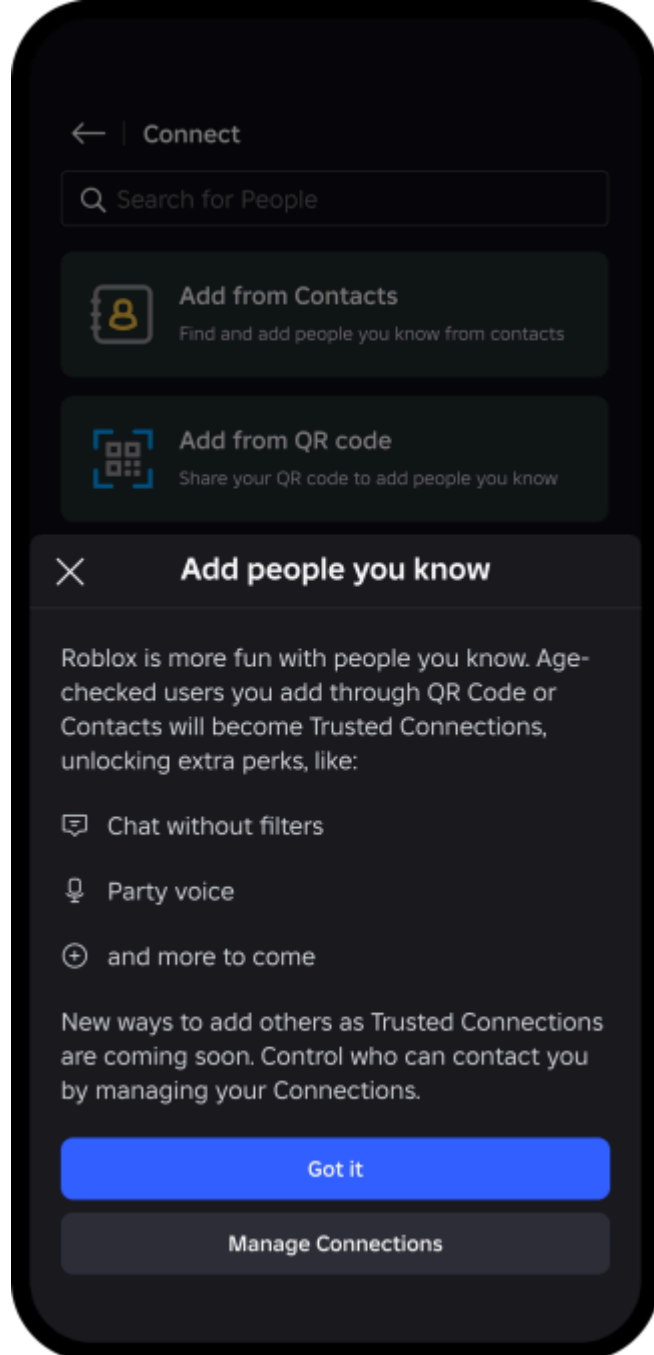


IMAGE CREDITS: ROBLOX

Roblox is renaming “Friends” to “Connections” and launching “Trusted Connections” to allow teens to communicate more freely in chat and voice with people they trust. With Trusted Connections, users can chat without filters.

“Users the system determines are 13+ will get access to more expressive chat features with their Trusted Connections,” said Ryan Ebanks, senior product manager at Roblox, in a briefing with reporters. “This additional freedom reduces the incentive for teens to move interactions off platform where they may be exposed to greater risk.”

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Roblox notes that conversations between Trusted Connections are proactively monitored for critical harm (e.g., grooming). Plus, parents can view who their teen is connected to as a Trusted Connection.

To unlock Trusted Connections, users need to use the platform's new age estimation technology to verify their age by taking a selfie video; they must receive an estimation of at least 13 years old to access Trusted Connections. Roblox notes that if the system is unable to verify age with high confidence, their age will remain unconfirmed. If the user doesn't pass the age estimation, they can confirm their age with ID verification.

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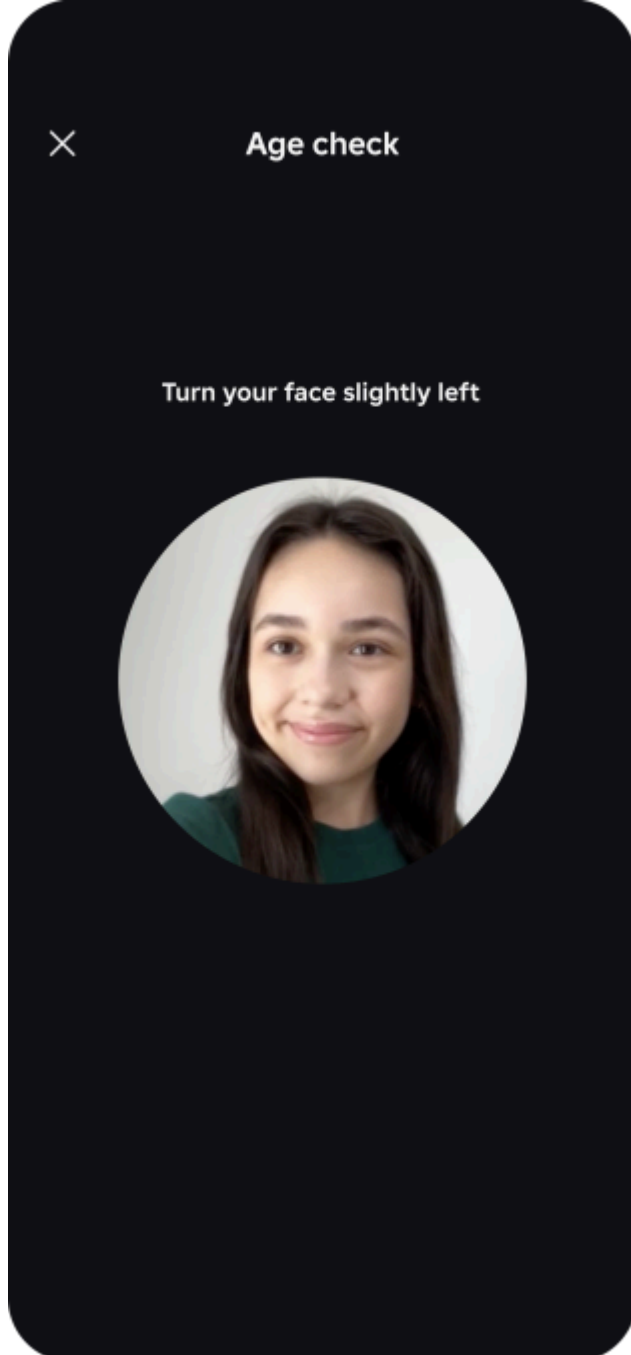


IMAGE CREDITS: ROBLOX

Users 13 to 17 who have their age confirmed can add each other as a Trusted Connection. Unfiltered communication between users aged 18 and above and teens is blocked unless a preexisting real-life relationship is verified via a QR code.

The company plans to use age estimation across its platform to support user access to age-appropriate features and content.

As for the new privacy tools, teens can now decide who can see if they're online. They can set this to be visible to just their Connections, followers, no one, or everyone on Roblox. They can now also set a

window during which push notifications from Roblox are silenced.

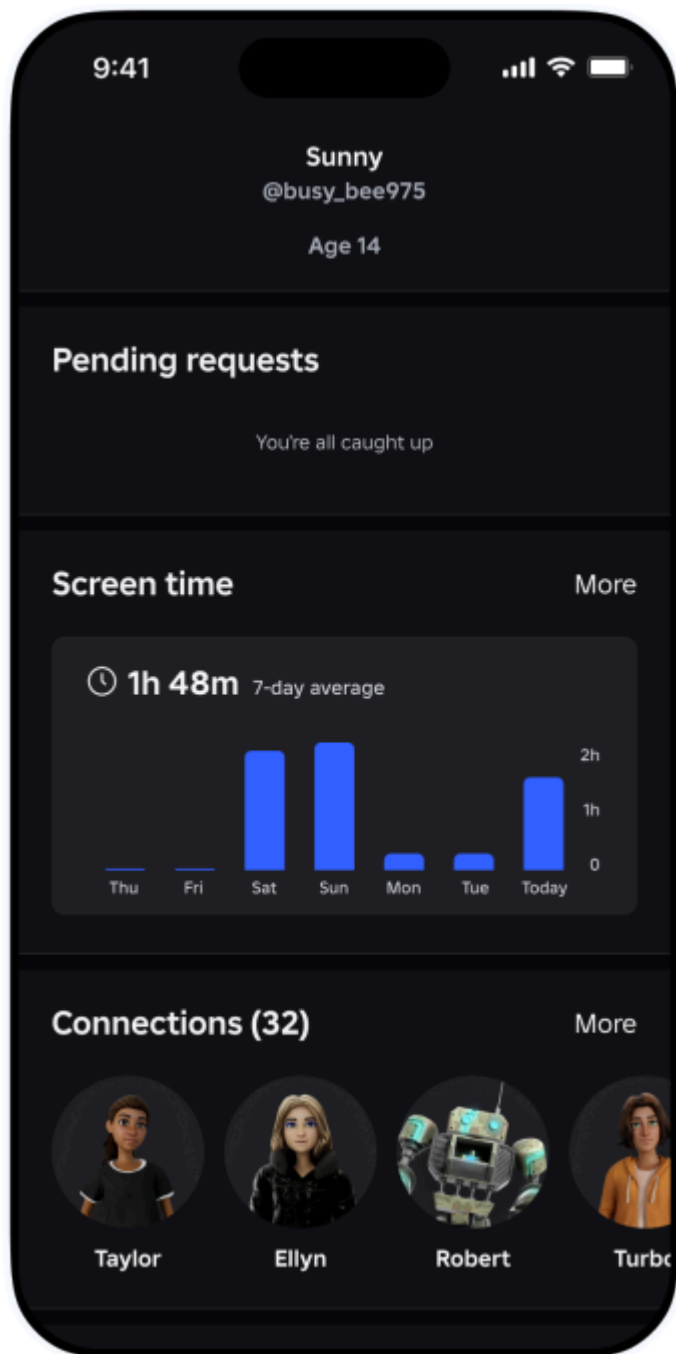


IMAGE CREDITS: ROBLOX

Roblox is giving parents access to a suite of tools to understand their child's usage and presence on the platform. Parents can now view who their teen is connected to, as well as how much time their teen spends on the platform and in which games. Plus, parents can choose to be notified when their teen makes a certain transaction on Roblox.

"We know that parents are extremely busy, and so we've designed these to really be quick at a glance insights that parents can hopefully fit into their busy

schedules,” said Dina Lamdany, senior product manager at Roblox, in the briefing.

Topics: [Apps](#) [Roblox](#)



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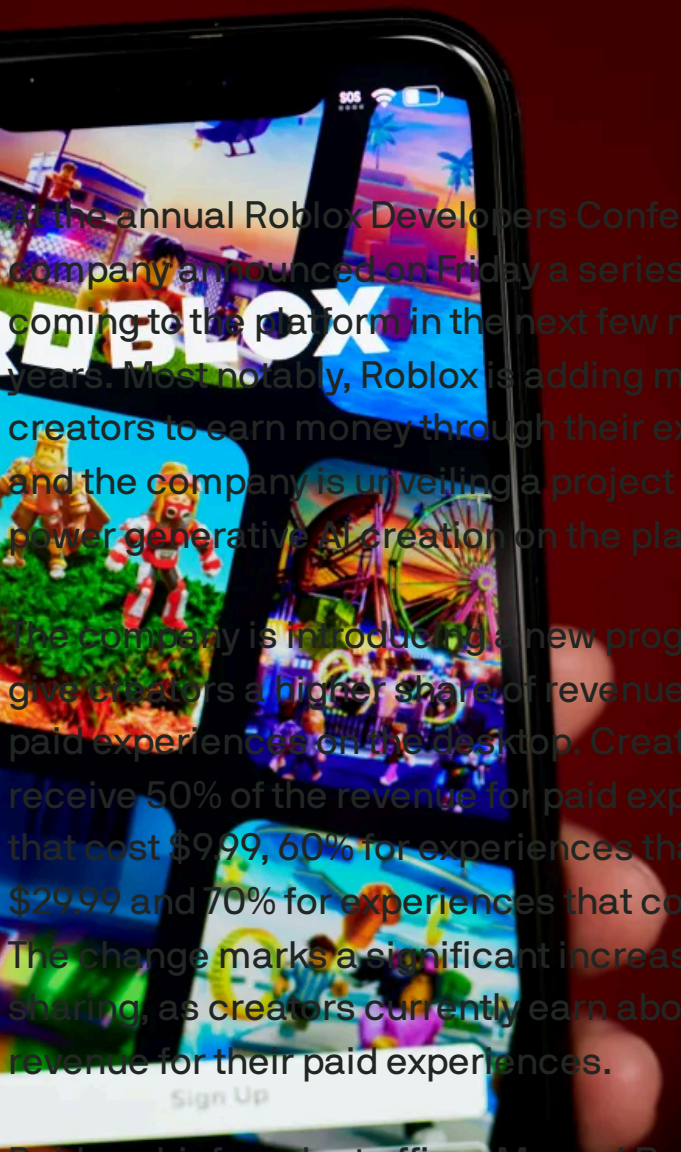
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Roblox introduces new earning opportunities for creators, teases generative AI project

Aisha Malik — 10:30 AM PDT · September 6, 2024



At the annual Roblox Developers Conference, the company announced on Friday a series of changes coming to the platform in the next few months and years. Most notably, Roblox is adding more ways for creators to earn money through their experiences, and the company is unveiling a project that will power generative AI creation on the platform.

The company is introducing a new program that will give creators a higher share of revenue for their paid experiences on the desktop. Creators will now receive 50% of the revenue for paid experiences that cost \$9.99, 60% for experiences that cost \$29.99 and 70% for experiences that cost \$49.99. The change marks a significant increase in revenue sharing, as creators currently earn about 25% of the revenue for their paid experiences.

Roblox chief product officer Manuel Bronstein told [TechCrunch](#) in an interview that the company believes this change will encourage more traditional game developers to bring their games to the platform.

IMAGE CREDITS:

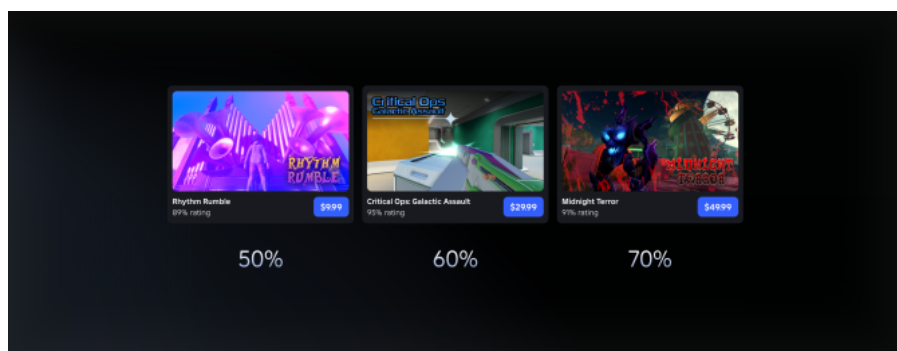


IMAGE CREDITS: ROBLOX

The company also announced that it's partnering with Shopify to allow creators to sell physical merchandise directly within their experiences. Roblox plans to pilot this integration later this year

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with select creators, brands and e-commerce partners.

To further support creators, Roblox is going to roll out a “Price Optimization” tool that will run tests to help developers identify the best price for in-experience purchases. In some cases, the tool may suggest that developers lower the price of an item to get more sales, benefiting both the developer and players.

In the same vein, the company is going to start

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“A creator could say I want to create a world that is in the Scottish Highlands with castles and a stormy day, with a dragon background, and I want all of this in a steampunk steam style. And then the output will be the full scene creation,” Bronstein said.

He noted that generative AI is currently focused on pictures and videos, not 3D creation. But, in Roblox, you need 3D objects, so if you see a tree, it needs to behave like a tree and also be visible from all sides.

Bronstein noted that Roblox isn't trying to replace the creative process but instead focuses on enabling more people to develop and create games. For instance, you may be a great developer but struggle with the artistic requirements for game creation. The 3D foundational model aims to make it easier for anybody to get started on the platform, while also helping current teams speed up the process of game development.

Plus, just because you get an output, doesn't mean that you will implement it right away. Developers will likely fine-tune and modify the AI-generated content, Bronstein said.

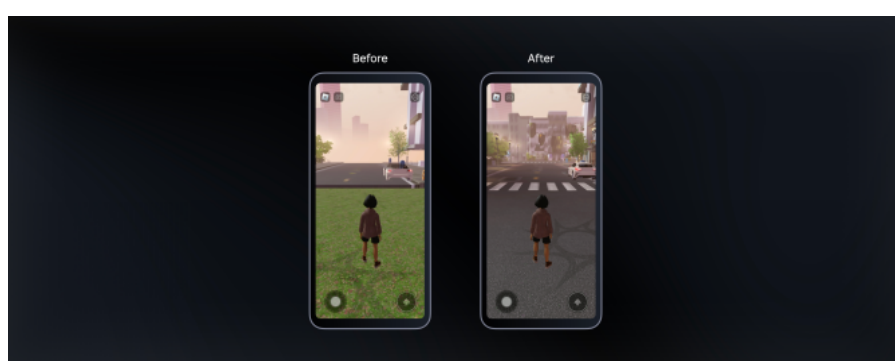


IMAGE CREDITS: ROBLOX

In addition, Roblox revealed that it's rolling out a new technology called "Harmony" that will help developers automatically optimize their experiences for different devices and network conditions.

Making Roblox more social

While Roblox already has social features that allow users to interact with each other, the company is introducing new ways for users to do so.

For starters, it's adding "Party," which is a new way for a group of friends to move around Roblox together as a group in a private chat. If a user is under the age of 13, they can chat via text. If a user is older, they can use voice chat. Users in a Party can chat with each other even if they're playing different games, and if they all want to play the same game, they can send invites to each other.

The company is also introducing forums later this year to give users a dedicated space to share feedback, discuss gameplay and report any issues they encounter.

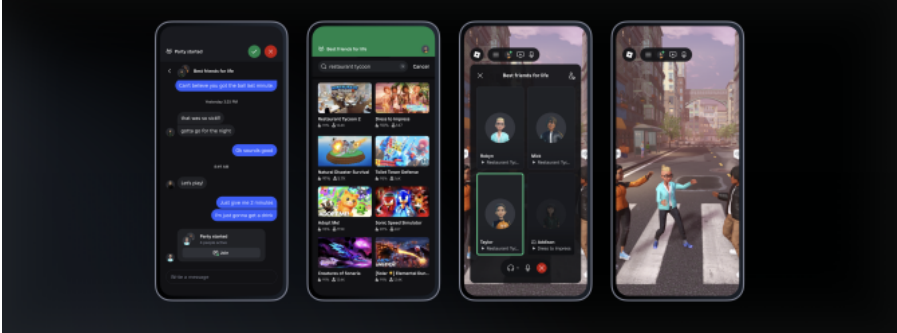


IMAGE CREDITS: ROBLOX

To make its platform a destination for people to discover new music, Roblox will roll out a new “What’s Playing” and “Music Charts” feature where people will be able to find trending songs from breakout artists. Roblox is also planning an integration with music distribution service DistroKid to give artists a way to upload and share their music on the platform.

All of the features announced today are part of Roblox’s ambitious goal of having 10% of all gaming content revenue worldwide flow through its ecosystem. Although the company didn’t provide a timeline for when it aims to reach this goal, Roblox believes the changes it is introducing will help it achieve the milestone.

Topics: [Apps](#) [Gaming](#) [Roblox](#)



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Roblox no longer allows users under 13 to message others outside of games

Aisha Malik — 4:00 AM PST · November 18, 2024

Roblox will not let users under the age of 13 message others outside of games and experiences on the platform, the company said Friday. Roblox also announced a series of other built-in protections for young users, such as age-gating certain experiences, along with enhanced parental controls.

Roblox has been criticized for failing to protect [children and young users from online predators](#), so these new features seem to be an attempt at regaining trust. A recent Bloomberg investigation exposed how [predators are able to find and groom children on Roblox](#).

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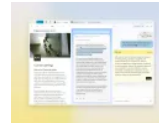
Latest in Apps

Shortly after the Bloomberg report was released, Roblox [said it would introduce changes](#) to keep children on its platform safe. Now, it's officially rolling out protections and giving parents more insight and control into their child's usage of the platform.

During a press briefing, the company explained that users under the age of 13 will still be able to access in-game chats because Roblox believes that communication is fundamental to gameplay on the platform. Parents can change this setting if they wish.

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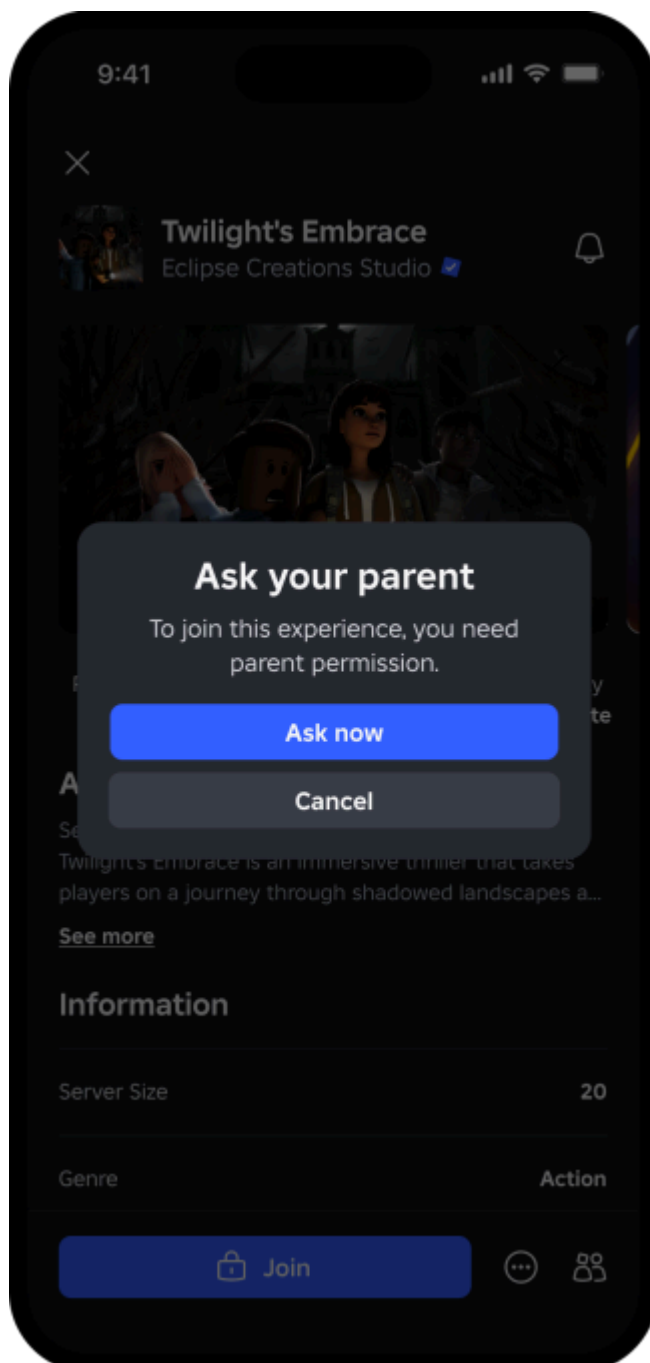


IMAGE CREDITS: ROBLOX

In addition, Roblox is age-gating certain experiences for users under 13. The new restrictions apply to games and experiences that are designed for socializing with people outside of a person's friends list, such as experiences that allow free-form writing or drawing.

"The reason that we've made this decision is that we've seen that some of both the content and the conduct in these experiences is more appropriate for older users and teens," said Dina Lamdany, Roblox's product lead for user settings and parental controls, during the press briefing.

Although Roblox already offers some parental controls, it previously only allowed them to be managed from a child's account. Now, the company is introducing remote management, which allows parents to adjust controls and see their child's activity from their own devices. To do so, parents can link their Roblox account to their child's account after verifying themselves using an ID or credit card.



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Parents can now also see their child's average weekly screen time and set daily time limits. They can also see their child's Friends list.

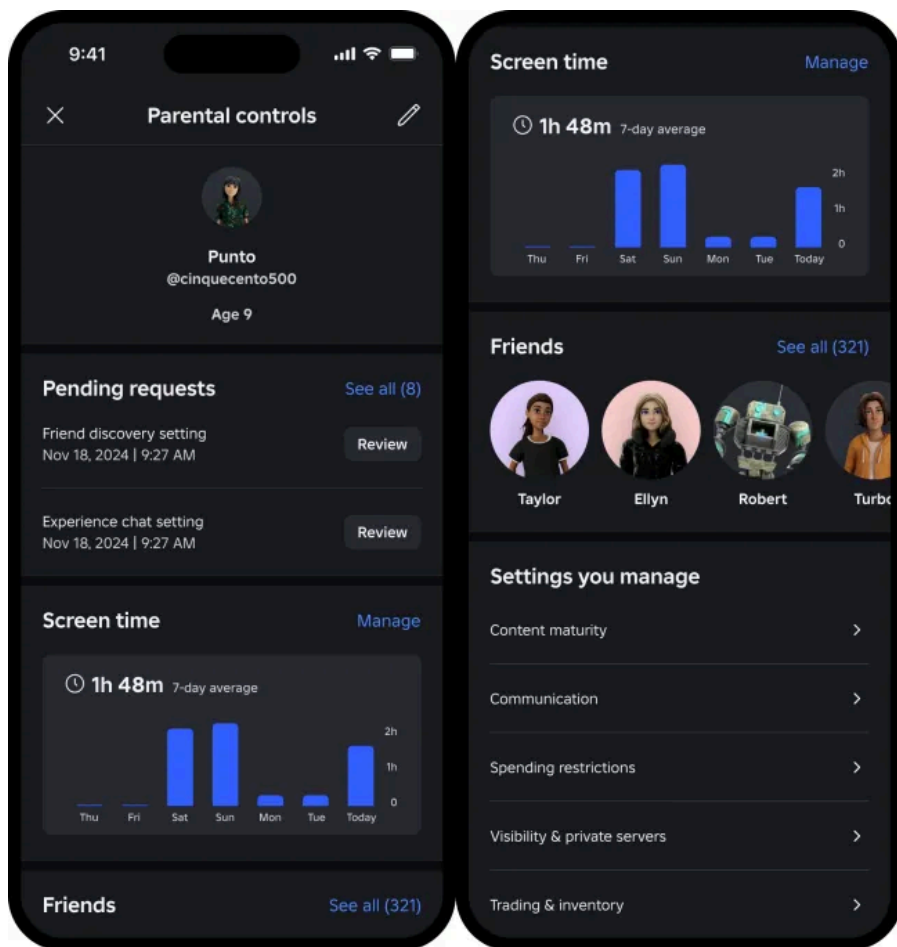


IMAGE CREDITS: ROBLOX

Up until now, Roblox has labeled experiences by age to display content maturity levels. Now, Roblox is launching simplified descriptions of the types of content available on the platform. If an experience is labeled “minimal,” that means it “may contain occasional mild violence, light unrealistic blood, and/or occasional mild fear.” A “mild” label means that an experience “may contain repeated mild violence, heavy unrealistic blood, mild crude humor, and/or repeated mild fear.”

An experience labeled “moderate” may contain “moderate violence, light realistic blood, moderate crude humor, unplayable gambling content, and/or moderate fear.” A “restricted” experience “may

contain strong violence, heavy realistic blood, moderate crude humor, romantic themes, unplayable gambling content, the presence of alcohol, strong language, and/or moderate fear.”

Users under the age of nine can only access “minimal” or “mild” content by default, and can only access “moderate content” with parental consent. Parents can select the level that they feel is best for their child.

Built-in protections on Roblox will now also be automatically removed once a child grows out of them and moves into another age group. Roblox will notify parents 30 days before their child’s age-based settings change.

“We really aim to be safe by default for users of all ages, and our policies and features will continue to adapt in service of that goal,” Lamdany said. “We think that doing so is the right thing for kids, for parents, creators, investors, and the company overall.”

The changes announced Friday will roll out to all users this week.

This story was updated to clarify that users under 13 cannot directly message others on the platform, regardless of parental permission.

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